

WALKING IN SPACE

"I felt red, white, and
blue all over."

EDWARD H. WHITE

ON HIS SPACE WALK, *LIFE* JUNE 1965



LIVING HIGH

Astronaut Ed White, pilot of the Gemini 4 mission, floats above the Earth during his historic space walk on June 3, 1965. In his right hand White holds the self-maneuvering gun which allowed him to propel himself through space, while remaining attached to the Gemini craft by a 25ft (8m) umbilical line.

THE SOVIET UNION'S DETERMINATION to remain ahead in the propaganda battle in space forced Sergei Korolev to rush into extra vehicular activity (EVA) – a space walk – before the right technology was in place. Aware that America's new Gemini project would probably lead to a space walk in 1965, Korolev set about adapting his Voskhod spacecraft to the purpose. Because the Soviets were still using vacuum-tube technology instead of circuit boards, the tube-filled interior of the Voskhod cabin could not be exposed to space. Instead, an inflatable airlock was fitted over the spacecraft's main hatch. A crew member would crawl into this, close the hatch behind him, and open the airlock hatch to float out into space.

On March 18, 1965, cosmonaut Alexei Leonov duly exited into space from Voskhod 2, tethered to the craft by an umbilical line that provided his air supply and a communications link to his colleague Pavel Belyayev who stayed behind to command the craft. Unfortunately, Leonov soon found himself spinning uncontrollably as his tether, which had become tangled, untwisted itself. Worse, when he attempted to reenter the airlock, he found his spacesuit had ballooned and he could no longer fit into the opening. He finally squeezed in after lowering the pressure in the suit. Even though Voskhod 2 had an eventful journey, completed by